

Session 10: The Lord's Supper

Key Takeaways

- The communion practices of the Corinthian Christians became rooted in the average culture, not Christ's love, creating injustice and abusive treatment toward the poor.
- "Do this in remembrance of me" (Jesus' instruction in the Gospels) is an invitation to remembrance by participation. We could paraphrase the idea as, "Do this, remembering that you are in me."
- The Spirit-filled and Jesus-centered community participates in God's presence, and the mark of this participation is love and care for the other.

Why Study the Early Eucharist?

In [this video](#), Professor Thomas O'Loughlin brings out the reality that Greco-Roman meals were highly stratified and a place for a rich man to demonstrate his largesse. So the table becomes a place where all social boundaries can be broken. It's a symbol of welcome and honor for those who are not normally honored in this way. The communion table is also a place of reconciliation.

Mary Patton Baker brings the themes of [chapter 10](#) and [chapter 11](#) together through the theme of participatory fellowship. Paul does not focus on the elements of the Eucharist, "Rather, he focuses on the nature and quality of Christian *κοινωνία* that is experienced in eucharistic celebration while contrasting it with being participants (*κοινωνός*) with demons in a pagan sacrifice ([1 Cor. 10:20](#))" (Patton Baker, 2014).

Koinonia as Participation

Paul is speaking to them about who is doing the sharing, what is being shared, and how it is being shared (Patton Baker, 2014). These themes run through the whole letter.

1. A sharing "in the Spirit," constituted primarily as communion with the triune God, and a sharing of the Spirit among those who are found in Christ
2. A sharing in the personal history of Jesus Christ through self-denial and identification with the sufferings of other Christians
3. This self-denial and identification is demonstrated when Christians share their material goods with those in need (Patton Baker, 2014)

[1 Corinthians 1:9](#) says, "God is faithful, who has called you into fellowship (Greek: *κοινωνία*) with his Son, Jesus Christ our Lord."

Patton Baker makes the point that the sharing or fellowship of the Spirit is the fellowship of the triune God and therefore, a person. "In simpler terms, sharing the fellowship of the Spirit means that believers are not sharing

in some thing, but with a divine someone.” (Patton Baker, 2014). And if we are sharing in the person of God, then we are sharing in the life of Christ, so the *κοινωνία* of Christians “must reflect the love of Christ” (Patton Baker, 2014).

In other words, this is not a ritual; it’s a lifestyle.

A Change in Lifestyle

The Corinthians were continuing to share in worldly relationships and pursuits. This was evident primarily in their division and their sexual immorality. They also wanted to avoid suffering at all costs. Perhaps because being seen to suffer was shameful?

In Romans 8:17, Paul declares that we will be co-sharers (Greek: *συγκληρονόμος*) in the inheritance of Christ “if, indeed, we share in his sufferings in order that we may also share in his glory.” But the Corinthians were avoiding self-denial and self-sacrifice where Paul was embracing these things “for the sake of the gospel.”

Patton Baker makes the point that this is also why Paul wants them to join in with the collection for the Jerusalem churches because those churches are suffering. Paul cites the Macedonians in 2 Corinthians as an example of those who give generously in extreme suffering. They considered being able to give even in their extremity as a privilege and a sign of God’s favor (2 Cor. 8:4) (Patton Baker, 2014).

Paul tries to explain to them that what we cling to or unite with in our bodies and through our bodies will affect how we behave. This will expose the motives of our hearts.

Paul uses the verb *κολλάω* (Greek: *kollao*—to cling to, or unite with). It’s the verb used in 1 Corinthians 6:16-17 about being “joined” or clinging to a prostitute or the Lord. The person you cling to is the one you are united with in spirit.

Baker picks up on a point made by Douglas Campbell that union describes something static, and participation describes something active.

Transformed Worship

The difference in Christian worship is that we are participating in the presence of God. We are not just bringing a sacrifice or an offering of something external to us; we are bringing ourselves, uniting with the persons of Christ and the Spirit, which has a transformational effect on the person.

As Baker points out, Paul says in Romans 12:1 to “offer your bodies as a living sacrifice.”

The Corinthians were proud and arrogant and excluded the poor and hungry from their meals. Patton Baker’s understanding of the phrase “discern the body of Christ,” is to see what is going on around us and the needs of others. “Those that considered themselves worthy were in fact unworthy because they did not ‘discern the body of Christ,’ i.e., the needs of those present (1 Cor. 11:29)” (Patton Baker, 2014).

The Spirit-filled and Christ-centred community participates in God’s presence and in the presence of one another, and the mark of this participation is love and care of the other. We wait for one another.

There is a looking back in order to learn from others, a looking around at those present, and a looking forward until the Lord comes ([1 Cor. 11:26](#)).

“The dual identification of the body as both Christ’s sacrificial presence and those who partake of his body is stunning. By partaking of the one loaf together, Christ’s body, worshippers celebrate and make manifest their *κοινωνία* of shared fellowship as Christ’s body. ... Participation in the body and blood of Christ is experienced through a community who loves and cares for each other, and at the same time this love and care for each other is strengthened by the Lord who presents himself to his church in his meal.”

Patton Baker, Mary (2014). “Participating in the Body and Blood of Christ.” [“In Christ” in Paul:: Explorations in Paul’s Theology of Union and Participation](#). Eerdmans. 523 and 525.

Reflection Question

In what ways can the Lord’s Supper/Eucharist/Communion become an enactment of justice?